

The Empower School
Anti-Bullying Policy



Anti-Bullying Policy
for

The Empower School Ltd

This Policy is available on our website.

This Policy is available on our website and is available on request from the referring school office. We also inform parents and carers about this policy when their children join our school via school referral.

This policy will be reviewed in full by The Empower School Ltd on an annual basis. This policy was last reviewed and agreed by the Directors of The Empower School Ltd on 20th January 2025. It is due for review on 20th January 2026.

Signature

Director

Date:

Signature

Director

Date:

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Introduction

The Empower School is committed to safeguarding and promoting the welfare of children and young people and expects all staff and volunteers to share this commitment.

Definition

The Empower School defines bullying as any behaviour by an individual or group, that intentionally hurts another individual or group either physically or emotionally. Bullying can take many forms, and is often motivated by prejudice against groups, for example:

Racism

Racism occurs when a person is subjected to abuse and harassment because of race, colour, beliefs, or ethnic background. It can be defined as;

- an individual believing that another person's race is inferior to theirs;
- racism can also be defined as an assumption that one race has the right to dominate or rule another;
- behaviour that is considered offensive or even aggressive to individuals who are of another race; • stereotyped comments;
- racist propaganda.

Religion

Bullying because of religion may have less to do with a person's beliefs and more to do with misinformation or negative perceptions about how someone expresses that belief. Sometimes Christian children are bullied by "non-believers" due to their faith in God or they may receive physical or verbal abuse from more aggressive "non-religious" children that poke fun at their beliefs or who want to prove they are stronger and more powerful than their "religious" peers. Similarly, children from non-Christian backgrounds such as Muslims, Jews, Sikhs or Buddhists may be bullied due to differences in their culture, dress and religious beliefs.

Homophobic/Transgender

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Homophobic/ transgender bullying occurs when people behave or speak in a way which makes someone feel bullied because of their actual or perceived sexuality. People may be a target of this type of bullying because of their appearance, behaviour, other physical traits or because they have friends or family who are LGBTQ+ or just because they are seen as being different. Some of the more common forms of homophobic / transgender bullying include;

- verbal bullying (being teased or called names, or being described in derogatory terms or with hate speech);
- being compared to LGBTQ+ celebrities / caricatures / characters that portray particular stereotypes of LGBTQ+ people;
- being 'outed' (the threat of being exposed to friends and family);
- indirect bullying / social exclusion (being ignored or left out);
- physical bullying;
- sexual harassment (inappropriate sexual gestures);
- cyber bullying (being teased, called names and/or threatened via email, text and on social networking sites).

Disability

One of the main reasons for children to bully others is that they are different, and they do not understand them. People's assumptions and prejudices about disability can make disabled children more vulnerable to bullying for a number of reasons, such as;

- negative attitudes towards disability;
- a lack of understanding of different disabilities and conditions;
- seeing disabled people as "different";
- they may be doing different work or have additional support at school;
- they may be more isolated due to their disability;
- they may find it harder to make friends, in addition to usual forms of bullying (as above), disabled children may also experience different forms of bullying, like;
 - manipulative bullying: where a person is controlling someone;

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- conditional friendship: where a child thinks someone is being their friend but phases of friendliness are alternated with phases of bullying;
- exploitative bullying: where features of a child's condition are used to bully them.

Distinct types of bullying

At The Empower School all forms of bullying are addressed swiftly and by the same standards. The Empower School recognises four distinct types of bullying:

1. **Verbal** - Verbal bullying means using words in a negative way such as insults, teasing or put downs, to gain power over someone else's life and cause them distress. Verbal bullying can also take the form of criticism, putting others down, spreading false rumours or threatening to cause someone harm.
2. **Physical** - Physical bullying is when one person or a group of people picks on or harasses another person in a face-to-face confrontational manner. It can be subtle actions to casually degrade the person over time, or it can be a series of more aggressive and direct acts to purposefully hurt the person in a more immediate fashion. Physical bullying can also sometimes be sexual in nature, as its psychological roots are based in the desire to dominate and control to make the perpetrator feel more powerful. Physical bullying can include harassment such as name calling or stalking behaviours, and more violent abuses such as hitting, torture, beating up and intimidating others.
3. **Emotional** - Emotional bullying is a deliberate attempt to hurt someone else, for example, cruel teasing, talking viciously about people behind their backs, spreading humiliating rumours, and excluding children from group activities.
4. **Cyber bullying**- Cyber bullying is when a child is threatened, harassed, tormented, and humiliated by another young person, child, or someone they know by use of the internet, social media websites, mobile phone voice messages and text messages to attack them.

Roles within Bullying

The Empower School recognise various roles within the act of bullying in accordance with guidance issued by the Anti-Bullying Alliance. The Empower School also recognises the variation in styles of bullying. Anything from intimidation through gesturing, 'looks' or 'evils' (which are all classed as non-verbal bullying), threats or extortion, homophobia, as well as gossip or exclusion from a group. Threatening texts, phone conversations and instant messages are also a style of bullying, though there is cross-over here with cyber-bullying.

Signs & Symptoms of Bullying

Bullying can often be detected early and subsequently stopped if staff and others are alert to certain signs and patterns of behaviour from a young person which then prompt investigation:

- An unwillingness to participate
- Being withdrawn or seeming depressed
- Seeming anxious
- A noticeable lack of confidence or nervous stammering
- Self-harming or other destructive behaviours
- Crying or looking visibly upset
- Trouble sleeping or having nightmares
- Regular illness or faking illness to get out of school or activities
- Poor quality of academic work
- Ripped clothing
- Damaged belongings
- Unexplained cuts and bruises
- A refusal to eat
- A refusal to say what is wrong
- Not wanting to talk about their day
- A decline in their grades
- Unexplained marks
- Loss of interest in friends
- Low self esteem

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- Change in eating habits Bullying of others (often those bullied start bullying others as a way to get out the anger they feel)

Aims & Objectives

The aim of this policy is to eradicate entirely from the day any form of bullying by creating an environment where every single young person and member of staff feels completely safe. This policy also aims to outline the strategies for eliminating bullying at The Empower School as well as the responses staff must make if bullying does occur.

The objectives of this policy are to make certain that there are well understood strategies that are implemented daily, and guidance to allow staff members and young people (to a lesser extent) to quash bullying entirely. A feeling of vulnerability is met with immediate protection and reassurance and an objective of this policy is for staff to make this completely apparent to all young people. Bullying is unacceptable. All allegations are investigated fully and carefully, but it is openness and honesty chiefly that can help ensure bullying doesn't begin in the first place and can be eliminated if it does begin. Staff will raise a bullying incident by recording it and promptly emailing it to the Programme Manager. If this occurs then the Programme Manager or DSL will speak to the victim. All staff are responsible for reporting bullying and making management aware.

Role of Staff

Management Leads facilitate any discussions regarding anti-bullying strategies and take on board what the staff have to say. Staff are always aware of issues between young people which might provoke The Empower School Anti-Bullying Policy.

Initially, staff should try to deal with conflict and develop strategies to prevent bullying occurring in the first place. This allows the intricacies of how a situation is to be dealt with to be discussed and understood by all staff.

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Directors are also obligated to organise necessary training for the staff, and to ensure that all staff, young people, parents and volunteers are completely up to date with all strategies.

Management Leads react to feedback from staff and relay relevant information from families, authorities etc. to the appropriate staff. The day-to-day implementation of anti-bullying strategies is the responsibility of all staff. They have an obligation to inform management of any situations where bullying is apparent. Staff also are encouraged to always promote positive relationships between our young people and anti-bullying.

Responses-Dealing with Incidents If an incident of bullying is either suspected or reported

It is the duty of the nearest member of staff to deal with any bullying incident. However, if there is either a racial or sexist element to the incident then the DSL/DDSL must be informed immediately.

General incidents of bullying require debrief at the end of the day with the relevant staff to discuss a plan of action. However, both parties - bullied and the bully - will have already been spoken to and the incident may have been dealt with and recorded. Parents will be kept informed, the incident is recorded and shared with the schools of the young person involved. Any follow up actions will be recorded by the Programme Manager/DSL/DDSL. The Empower School strives to ensure the bullied young person's feelings are being heard and believes that reassurance is vital- all staff members should express the importance of letting an adult deal with the situation. It is crucial, though, to gauge the different reactions of different victims (but also of the bullies), this will allow the staff member to direct the young person to the right member of staff i.e. the one who will adopt the appropriate tact and has the greatest and most positive influence on the particular young person.

Incidents of bullying are reported in full through email to the Programme Manager/DSL/DDSL and the key workers of the young people involved. The reporting process is largely to allow patterns of behaviour to be identified and

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subsequently altered for the better. An important element is to determine how the incident was detected e.g. hearsay, gossip, direct witness.

Support & Confidentiality

Staff will reassure young people that feel they have been bullied, and concerns will be shared on a need to know basis. The Empower School recognises that in many cases the bully will also need a form of support. The support will be based around the idea of changing attitudes and linking to our values. We will try to understand the bully's perspective and then advise from that point. The Empower School recognises that the problem will not be solved by simply quashing the incident, the real solution will be an alteration in attitude and behaviour. Staff to steer young person's conversations towards positive topics. A proactive nature in curbing negative topics and topics that could lead to nasty comments is encouraged. This way young people also have an immediate reference should they encounter negativity as staff will be always vigilant.

Interventions

The Empower School also considers the motivation behind bullying behaviour and what it reveals about the perpetrator and whether they need support themselves. Leading Managers and Key workers will pull together information, relevant to the incident. Lead managers must be made aware of all relevant information. Both the bullied and the bully are made immediately aware of the response. Typically, if there is a clear solution to the incident the consequence may be a letter of apology, a direct verbal apology, etc

Parents and carers are made aware that The Empower School does not tolerate bullying and have procedures to follow if they feel their child is being bullied.

Parents/carers should feel confident that The Empower School will take any complaint seriously and will be investigated accordingly.

Involving Young People

Young people at The Empower School should adhere to a simple set of guiding values that provide the basis of young people's behaviour. All young people should understand the school's approach and be clear about the part they play to prevent bullying. Coping strategies will be discussed as will mentality and awareness of the facets that make up bullying.

Complaints Procedure

Any complaints about anti-bullying procedures should be made to The Empower School DSL via email. The procedures outlined in the policy also apply to off-site incidents of bullying where the young persons are involved in activities e.g. trips, sport sessions etc. Incidents completely independent of school will be investigated by the Police, however, in such cases The Empower School prefers to be notified, but that is at the discretion of the young person's parents/guardians.